PLAYMAKER · PLAYING LEVELS

These levels are representative: they reproduce how each level of basketball differs from the pros, not any one league exactly. The pro cards are set at senior pro level (FIBA and NBL). The rules never change. Set two dials before you build teams, the same for both sides.

DIAL 1 · AGE which cards you use

Senior	Pro cards.
Elite youth · U18 to U20	Pro cards, plus: every shot and free throw –1; Steal and Intercept +1. Young players shoot about 4 points worse and lose the ball to steals more often; fouls and contests are the same.
Junior · U14 to U16	U16 cards, plus growth tags (below). Weaker shooting and ball security, types closer together, and size and speed set by growth, not position.

DIAL 2 · STANDARD which tiers you build with

Pro	**BBBBB · ABBBC · AABCC**	The full range of tiers.
Semi-pro	**BBBBC · ABBCC**	A little below pro.
Amateur	**BBCCC · ACCCC**	Mostly C. ACCCC is the club with one standout.

Pick any shape in your standard; every shape in a row is equal strength (A = +1, B = 0, C = –1). Lower tiers weaken offence and defence together, as real lower leagues do, and amateur players are the most spread out: the best are close to pro, the rest well short. For a handicap, give the less experienced player a higher standard.

EXAMPLES

NBL, EuroLeague	**Senior · Pro**	U19 World Cup	**Elite youth · Pro**
NBL1, state league	**Senior · Semi-pro**	State U16 squad	**Junior · Pro**
Local club men's	**Senior · Amateur**	Club U14 team	**Junior · Amateur**

The same at every level: contest ratings, foul ratings, Screen, Challenge, Agility and Quick Step (apart from growth tags). A contest costs every shooter the same points, so it hurts weaker shooters more. Against the computer, its level (Rookie, Starter, All-Star) sets how well it reads the play; choose it separately.

JUNIOR GROWTH TAGS

U16 cards show an on-time player. Each team shuffles five tags (1 Early, 3 On time, 1 Late), deals one face down to each player and reveals them at setup.

Early	Quick Step +1 (max 2), Agility +1, Challenge +1. Screen, Dunk, Post Move and Contest on layup, dunk and post +2.
On time	No change.
Late	The reverse: Quick Step –1 (min 0), Agility –1, Challenge –1. Screen, Dunk, Post Move and those contests –2.

Sources: FIBA U19 World Cup 2023 and World Cup 2023 European Qualifiers team statistics; Baltic Journal of Sport and Health Sciences (Lithuanian national teams by age, 2015); Frontiers in Psychology 2022 (U15 performance by position and selection); Life 2026 and Scientific Reports 2021 (maturity and physical performance); NBA.com, basketball.com.au, NCAA.com, Synergy and ShotTracker (level comparisons).